

The choices you make

A couple of months ago I wrote a sarcastic / satirical piece about SOPA (Stop Online Piracy Act). As expected, I got a couple of hate mails from people who didn't read the whole column, and actually believed I was campaigning for such idiocy. Oh well!

However, I also got mail from people who not only understood the sarcasm, but also agreed with my views. People are just not comfortable with being told what to do online, or what they can or can't view. We like our little freedoms – the freedom to express our views and the freedom to look at every other point of view.

However, we're also extremely testy and sensitive about certain things – religion is a prime example. Terrorism is also something we abhor enough to sacrifice a few non-essential liberties without making too much of a fuss. Every traveller to the US from this country is now completely used to being treated as if guilty until proven innocent at airports. We shrug our shoulders and quietly try to put on our socks and shoes in a corner. "It's just the way the world is now", someone once told me.

Right here at home, terrorism is as big a threat as anywhere else in the world, and especially in Mumbai, where I live. People seem almost indifferent to it now – "It happens. So many people. What can authorities really do?", another friend once said.

That said, we all oppose SOPA. We're all against invasions of our privacy. Those who own BlackBerrys nod their heads disapprovingly and make little clicking noises with their tongues at the news that RIM had to set up servers in Mumbai to allow the Indian Government to gain access to BBM (messenger) chats – because terrorists can, and have used BBM to co-ordinate attacks. Of course they could use email, Yahoo! Messenger, WhatsApp, GTalk, Facebook chat, and a myriad other ways to communicate as well. So are those being monitored already? Perhaps every email you send and receive is already being monitored. Maybe your Facebook activity is under the scanner – every wall post, every picture you put, what your friends talk about, which videos you watch, how badly you spell and who you think is "cute" even.

Why stop there? maybe absolutely everything you do on a device that's connected to some sort of network is being fed to computing farms to analyse the content and create a profile of you. I'll bet mine says, "wastes a little too much time watching stand-up comedians on

YouTube; extremely boring otherwise." Ever wondered what yours would say?

If you're thinking, "Nah, that's not possible. There's no way all of our data is being analysed.", you're wrong of course. It very much is, has been for a long time, and there's nothing you can do about it!

Whether the government is doing so or not, I really have no clue, and if they are, then it's just another set of algorithms being run on my data, or profile, or whatever they call it. However, I do know that pretty much everything you do online is recorded somewhere, in some form and analysed for various reasons. The biggest reason is money of course – you and your habits – buying, surfing, etc. – are all worth something to someone.

Yes, Google and Facebook, and every other site you visit are doing this analysis of you, and everything you do. They do it to try and decide what kind of ads you would be more likely to click on, and slot all of us into nice, neat little piles of humanity to be monetised when possible.

Nothing wrong with that, of course – if you like the service Google or Facebook provide, so what if they make money while providing you that service for free? You can go to <http://t.co/hSxzJaPf> to see what information the Google cookie stores about you. Of course, they have a separate data store somewhere about your Gmail account, your search habits, YouTube videos you like, and all the stuff you do when logged in, and even all the stuff your IP or browser does when not logged in. At Facebook, since you can't do anything without being signed into your account, the data is probably much more precise and "real". And yes, even those adult sites you didn't think anyone knows you visit – they know!

So why is it we like to moan about our Governments monitoring our mails or IMs for keywords, and start discussing our democratic rights, but the fact that the companies and corporations of the world have much more in-depth and intimate knowledge about you doesn't even elicit a whimper?

Perhaps it's because you have no individual-level control over who governs you as a citizen, but using a service that stores your data... well that's a choice you make. Write in and tell me what you think. 



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Liked or hated this column?
Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com and let me know your thoughts.